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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1954-1957

Coverage Date: 1930-1957

Place Coverage

Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): AGGRESSIVE OFFENSES

Such nonaggressive behavior often belies deep-seated ill feelings between Gusii individuals. This is recognized in the proverb, "People may be seen together but their hearts do not know each other." A case that arose in Nyansongo (described in Chapter 9) illustrates this concretely. When Mogaka died, his older widow made it known to numerous neighbors that she blamed two male neighbors, closely related to the deceased, with having killed him by sorcery. The two men knew of her charges, and they issued counter-accusations to other neighbors, imputing foul deeds to the widow's family. This was a serious and notorious situation in the community. But, a week after the death, when the sacrifice for the dead man was performed, not only were both men present and assisting in the ritual, but at the informal meal afterward, the widow was joking with them, good-naturedly encouraging one of them to take her younger co-wife as a leviratic wife, and so on. Their interaction betrayed none of the hostility they felt toward one another. Shortly afterward, the older widow was the sole complainant in the trial of one of the men for sorcery, and she uttered her charges publicly. This is a striking illustration of the Nyansongo ability to suppress aggression in direct interaction with the object of the aggression and their tendency to express it in back-biting and litigation.

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Nyansongans are not highly sociable people, and they view their neighbors with considerable suspicion. "Homesteads are secret hiding places" is one oft-quoted proverb, and another warns, "A thicket has eyes," counseling caution about speech in the manner of our own wartime slogan, "The walls have ears." Sociability is equated with danger in two proverbs. "He who enters doors will be found with a swollen intestine," refers to a postmortem sign of death by witchcraft as the consequence of going into other people's houses. "Eat like the hide-dresser," is considered an admonition to stay out of trouble by eating at home like the dresser of hides, whose work prevents his visiting his  78 fellows. Few Nyansongans follow the extreme advice of such proverbs, but they share anxieties expressed in them. Privacy is desired and available, and it gives individuals the opportunity to conspire and talk against

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each other. Everyone is aware of this, and thus when people come together for work and entertainment, which is rather frequently, each one comes with at least a slight feeling of distrust.

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